



No Strings Attached: Puppets on Film

Child's Play

Child's Play

Director: Tom Holland

Production Company: United Artists

Executive Producers: Barrie Osborne, Elliot Geisinger

Producer: David Kirschner

Associate Producer: Laura Moskowitz

Production Associate: Judy Groffman

Production Managers: Robert Latham Brown, Carl Olsen

Production Office Co-ordinator: Mary Courtney

Location Managers: John Ross Bush, Michael J. Malone

Production Assistants: Aaron Osborne, Gary Agriesti, Hal G. Reinstra, Victor Bazaz

2nd Unit Director: Bud Davis

Assistant Directors: Michael Green, Linnea Ebba Wicklund, George Fortmuller

2nd Unit Assistant Directors:

James R. Giovannetti Jr, Stefanie Moore

Insert Unit Assistant Director: Arthur Anderson

Casting: Richard Pagano, Sharon Bialy

Chicago Casting: Jane Alderman, Shelley Andreas

Screenplay: Don Mancini, John Lafia, Tom Holland

Original story: Don Mancini

Director of Photography: Bill Butler

2nd Unit Photographer: James Blanford

Camera Operator: Jim Connell

Insert Unit Camera Operator: Peter Salim

Chicago Steadicam Operator: Robert K. Ulland

Visual Effects Supervisor: Peter Donen, Apogee Inc.

Process Projection: Hansard

Special Effects Supervisor: Richard O. Helmer

Special Effects: James D. Schwalm

Chucky doll created by: David Kirschner

Chucky doll designed/executed by: Kevin Yagher

Chucky Construction Unit Shop Supervisor:

Howard Berger

'Good Guy' illustrations: Beverly Lazor-Bahr

Animation sequence: Ruby-Spears Enterprises

Editors: Edward A. Warschilka, Roy Peterson

Additional Editor: Scott Wallace

Production Designer: Dan Lomino

Set Designers: James E. Tocci,

William David Arnold, Gary Baugh

Set Decorator: Claudia

Costume Designer: April Ferry

Costume Supervisor: Mort Schwartz

Set Costumers: Ed Burza, Barbara McHugh

Costumer (Chicago): Irene Grzejka

Makeup Artist: Michael Hancock

Chucky Puppeteers: Allen Coulter, Loren Soman,

Howard Berger, Frank Charles Lutkus III, Steve

James, Marc Tyler, N. Brock Winkless IV, David

Arthur Nelson, Bill Bryan

Title Design: Wayne Fitzgerald

Opticals: Cinema Research Corporation

Music: Joe Renzetti

Synclavier Programming: Craig Harris

Orchestrations: Arlon Ober

Music Supervisor: David Chackler

Music Editor: Ted Whitfield

Sound Recording: James E. Webb Jr

Dialogue re-recording: Don Mitchell, Rick Kline, Kevin O'Connell

Supervising Sound Editor: John Riordan

Sound Editors: Harry Cheney, Clayton Collins,

Sherman Waze, Kirk Schuler, Daniel Yale

ADR Editors: George R. Steven, Ronald Sinclair

Stunt Co-ordinator: Bud Davis

Stunt double for Chucky: Ed Gale

Chucky is a sweet-looking 'Good Guy' doll which becomes hideously evil when its body is inhabited by the soul of a killer.

Like many other movie stars, Chucky's off-screen persona is totally unlike his nasty behaviour on camera. Around the set, he loved to crack up cast and crew alike by dancing, telling jokes, doing impressions, singing and laughing.

The most elaborate and sophisticated 'creature' ever built for film, Chucky was created by David Kirschner and designed and operated by Kevin Yagher and eight members of his staff. Actually, nine Chuckies were made for *Child's Play*. The simple 'toy' doll which appears at the beginning; a doll which could stand without visible means of support; a walking doll; a couple of hand-puppets which could sit, flail and bite for use in close-ups and expendable stunt dolls for hurling against walls or other similarly brutal treatment called for in the script.

Creating the dolls required 45 sheets of plastic for the shells, hundreds of pounds of plaster for the moulds, and 30 gallons of silicone rubber for the face and hands. In addition to the complete dolls, the dollmakers turned out 50 pairs of interchangeable hands, 35 costumes and 20 pairs of shoes. 500 feet of cable was used for the manual controls.

Chucky's face was more expressive than many human ones. He could look sad or mean. He could even squint, scowl or smile because of 17 servo motors attached to little tabs strategically placed inside his realistic-looking skin. One of the most fascinating pieces of equipment was a headbrace-transmitter which replicated movements of the puppeteer's face on Chucky. Four joysticks positioned the lips for making different vowels and consonants of words which were later dubbed in by Brad Dourif. The doll's brows, baby blues and mouth were operated by three puppeteers using remote control units. Two more operated the arms, one the hands, another the head and a lead puppeteer controlled the body and cued the others.

An astonishing amount of coordination had to be achieved among them for even the simplest movements. If seven puppeteers moved simultaneously but the head was a second slow or the eyes an inch in the wrong direction, the effect was ruined.

'At first, Chucky was like a little baby deer just starting out, stumbling and falling all the time. Then it was amazing,' enthused Yagher. 'Even to the guys who controlled him, it seemed as if he was coming alive before our eyes.'

In the end, to all those who worked with him on *Child's Play*, he wasn't a doll. He was just ... Chucky.

Production notes

A contemporary review

That toys have a life of their own is an undisputed fact among nursery occupants, writers of children's books, and occasional fantasists like Angela Carter or Theodore Sturgeon (whose classic tale of a bloodsucking teddy still evokes a shudder). In the cinema, dolls from *Pinocchio* to *D.A.R.Y.L.* have with increasing frequency strutted their stuff, symbols of the mysterious logic and longings of the adult world and signs, at the same time, that a genuine android

Cast:

Catherine Hicks (*Karen Barclay*)
Chris Sarandon (*Mike Norris*)
Alex Vincent (*Andy Barclay*)
Brad Dourif (*Charles Lee Ray*)
Dinah Manoff (*Maggie Peterson*)
Tommy Swerdlow (*Jack Santos*)
Jack Colvin (*Dr Ardmore*)
Neil Giuntoli (*Eddie Caputo*)
Juan Ramirez (*peddler*)
Alan Wilder (*Mr Criswell*)
Richard Baird (*news reporter at toy store*)
Raymond Oliver (*John Bishop, 'Dr Death'*)
Aaron Osborne (*orderly*)
Tyler Hard (*Mona*)
Ted Liss (*George*)
Roslyn Alexander (*Lucy*)
Robert Kane (*male TV newscaster*)
Leila Hee Olsen (*female TV newscaster*)
Lena Sack, Tommy Gerard, Michael Chavez, Jamie Gray, Erin Munz, Jana Twomey, Suaundra Black (*Bellevue patients*)
Edan Gross (*voice of Friendly Chucky*)
Brad Dourif (*voice of Chucky*)
John Franklin (*voice of Walkabout Chucky*)
Edan Gross, Michael Patrick Carter (*voices of kids in animated commercial*)
USA 1988
87 mins
Digital

Become a BFI Member

Enjoy a great package of film benefits including priority booking at BFI Southbank and BFI Festivals. Join today at bfi.org.uk/join

Sight and Sound

Never miss an issue with **Sight and Sound**, the BFI's internationally renowned film magazine. Subscribe from just £25*

* Price based on a 6-month print subscription (UK only). More info:

sightandsoundsubs.bfi.org.uk/subscribe



BFI Player

We are always open online on BFI Player where you can watch the best new, cult & classic cinema on demand. Showcasing hand-picked landmark British and independent titles, films are available to watch in three distinct ways: Subscription, Rentals & Free to view.

See something different today on player.bfi.org.uk

invasion is in preparation for our immediate future. The homicidal dummy of *Child's Play*, however, owes less to the berserk avengers of *Westworld* than to the psychotic instruments of *Dead of Night* and *Magic*, in which animated models take the pain and blame for their deranged owners. Sadly, the more serious explorations suggested by *Child's Play* seem to have been briskly discarded. All that remains as potential insight is a weak and woolly observation about the vulnerability of infants to the cynicism of hard-sell television advertising, and the obvious but unforced irony that, in one child's experience, the much-touted 'Good Guys' turn out to be a lethal nightmare.

Since the repellent playmate, Chucky, incarnates the Lakeside Strangler by virtue of some ludicrous supernatural gobbledegook (as implausible, but nowhere near as charming, as Lionel Barrymore's thought-control technique in Tod Browning's dotty *Devil Doll* of 1936), his coherence as a warning of consumerist peril is disastrously betrayed even as the story opens. By its close, Chucky's real purpose – as a killing machine that, in the fashion of today's horror films, keeps on coming despite graphic dismemberment – is enervatingly clear. It may be unreasonable to expect logic within a tale of such amiable contrivance, but *Child's Play* seems constructed on the basis that if we'll accept the idea of a mass murderer spiriting himself into a doll we'll accept anything. No amount of exchanges between the central characters that they don't believe what they're seeing can convince us that they're wrong, chiefly because, despite industrious performances (both Catherine Hicks and Chris Sarandon manage to suggest complex private commitments without actually giving any details at all), both characterisation and context are sparsely sketched.

Among other obscurities, it is uncertain why the Strangler should wish to blow up (by complicated and unlikely means) his former colleague, while the assertion by his voodoo guide that the killer must transfer his soul to the first person he told his secret to seems a blatant example of making up the rules to suit the plot. Which said, there is no doubt that Chucky becomes a pleasingly demented figure of menace, his plastic features increasingly weird turning, and that Tom Holland mightily enjoys the action sequences – the exploding toy shop, the defenestration of the babysitter, the driver struggling to stay on the road as a knife plunges up through the car seat, the pest-disposal mayhem of the final struggle. The vampire neighbours of *Fright Night* were more fun, but the signs remain that Holland can handle a good story when he finds one. His most accurate stroke of horror in *Child's Play* is neatly mundane: the birthday kid's loving preparation of his mother's breakfast tray produces a mound of lurid cereals and charred toast congealing in a lake of fruit juice and milk...

Philip Strick, *Monthly Film Bulletin*, June 1989